The HIGHLANDS Current

NEWS: BEACON NEWS

Dutchess to End Flock Camera Use



by **Jeff Simms**
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District attorney, sheriff respond after public forum

The Dutchess County district attorney and sheriff announced on Friday (Sept. 25) that, following a public forum in Pleasant Valley, they no longer support the county's use of Flock license-plate readers.

At the same time, the county executive said the $500,000 budgeted next year for the cameras would be diverted to other resources and Democrats in the county Legislature **called for the county to immediately suspend data collection** and to cover the cameras until they can be removed. They said a resolution to enact the changes will be introduced at the Legislature's committee meetings next month.

The flurry of announcements came after about 30 speakers uniformly opposed the technology during the Wednesday (Sept. 23) forum in Pleasant Valley. It was organized by Eric Alexander, a Democrat who represents municipalities in central Dutchess and chairs the Legislature's Public Safety Committee.

At the forum, District Attorney Anthony Parisi said he wanted to see 20 "non-negotiable" changes to the next contract with Flock Safety, including disclosing what the company does with the data collected in Dutchess, or he would oppose a new agreement, **reporting by *The Daily Catch***. The current contract, which includes 65 LPR cameras, expired on Aug. 28, but the cameras remain active during renewal negotiations.



Dutchess D.A. Anthony Parisi spoke Wednesday (Sept. 23) at a forum on license-plate readers. (Photo by Athan Yanos/*The Daily Catch*)

In a statement released on Sept. 25, County Executive Sue Serino said she would not renew the Flock contract. “If the district attorney and the sheriff no longer believe that Flock Safety technology is a tool that they need, I stand by them in that decision,” she said. “As the sheriff and the district attorney begin the process of rescinding the Flock contracts and dismantling the network, I commend them for being responsive to community concerns and being willing to change course.”

Serino said that she would recommend diverting the $500,000 allocated in the district attorney’s 2027 budget for LPRs “to help protect many other critical programs and services that our neighbors depend on, including EMS services, veterans, seniors and youth programming.” Had she included the funding in her 2027 budget proposal, the Legislature could have removed it, Alexander said.

The county had six contracts with Flock spanning October 2022 to Aug. 28, according to the Dutchess Comptroller’s Office, which posted them at **dub.sh/DC-flock-contracts**. They ranged from $63,000 to $199,950.

Using artificial intelligence, the Flock system analyzes photos of passing vehicles, records their plate numbers and categorizes them by make and model, color and any damage. The system’s database is searchable by law-enforcement agencies seeking stolen vehicles, criminal suspects and missing persons. Overall, the network

includes 437 cameras in Dutchess, including those on private land and on roads controlled by the state and townships.

Dutchess officials said that the contract with Flock stipulates that only the county owns the local data and that it cannot be sold to third parties, but Parisi told *The Daily Catch* this week that the county has limited control over what the company does.

“The reality is, we talk about the security, we talk about the information, [but] it’s not sitting on a Dutchess County server, so the control that we have is limited,” Parisi said. “Once we contract with private companies, we’re relying on what they’re telling us to be true. … I can’t go in and see everything that Flock personnel are [doing].”

In their **Friday statement**, Parisi, elected as a Democrat, and Sheriff Kirk Imperati, a Republican, said they “spent considerable time discussing what we heard from residents.” Parisi said: “We agreed that the appropriate response is to listen to our community and change course.”

According to Imperati, “The district attorney and I supported this technology because we believed it could help law enforcement protect people and investigate serious crimes. We still care deeply about giving our officers and deputies the tools they need to do that work. But we also heard the concerns.”

Images collected by Flock cameras are transmitted to the Dutchess County Analysis and Real-Time Crime Intelligence Center. Dutchess is one of about 1,500 agencies nationwide that participate in a Flock program that posts statistics about its local use during the previous 30 days, before the data is deleted (see **dub.sh/dutchess-flock**).

During the 30 days before Sept. 25, the Dutchess County cameras recorded the plates of 727,493 vehicles, with 100,046 “hits” for alerts sent by the National Crime Information Center, the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children and New York State for suspended vehicle tags. Officers at the Real Time Crime Center made 188 searches.

More Flock News

Peekskill Chief Defends Cameras

Police Chief Adam Renwick spoke to the Common Council on Sept. 14 about his department's use of license-plate cameras, according to *The Peekskill Herald*.

Renwick said the city recently installed 15 LPRs at four intersections. It also has two mobile cameras, and DeFlock Maps, a crowd-sourced project, says two cameras at Bay Street Bridge capture Route 9 traffic for Westchester County police.

"Our policy prohibits personal, political, retaliatory, discriminatory and other non-official uses," Renwick said of the city's LPRs. "It also prohibits using or sharing LPR information solely for civil immigration enforcement."

The data from the cameras is shared with the Westchester County Real Time Crime Center for use by other law enforcement agencies, including all 40 police departments in Westchester, four in Putnam County, and the state police and Metropolitan Transportation Authority (MTA) Police.

"No technology can eliminate the possibility of human misuse," Renwick said. "The relevant question is whether its use is limited, attributable to an individual, reviewable and subject to consequences."

Newburgh Council to Vote on Contract

The Newburgh City Council is expected on Monday (Sept. 28) to vote to dissolve its contract with Flock Safety.

A proposed resolution cites "substantial concerns regarding access to and sharing of locally collected ALPR [automated license-plate reader] information across jurisdictions and with other law-enforcement agencies, including federal agencies" and concludes the technology "is no longer consistent with the city's policy priorities regarding privacy, civil liberties, public accountability and community trust."

The city said its contract with Flock began on Aug. 6, 2024, and was renewed on Jan. 1, 2026. City attorney Michele Kelson told council members on Sept. 24 that the council, city manager, corporation counsel and police chief would all be involved in ending the

> contract, according to *Mid Hudson News*. If the council approves the resolution, the system would be shut down within 14 days.

Flock cameras were first deployed in 2017 in the Georgia neighborhood of one of the company's founders. The technology has been criticized nationwide as allegations of misuse have arisen. Officers have been accused of using the data to stalk romantic partners; opponents say the images have also been searched by federal and out-of-state agencies without local knowledge. Dutchess legislators said in their statement that stolen police logins have been offered for sale online and camera misreads have led to "innocent families being stopped at gunpoint."

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In Beacon, Police Chief Tom Figlia spoke to the City Council on Monday (Sept. 21) about **the city's seven Flock cameras**. He said on Friday that he was caught off guard by Imperati and Parisi's change of heart.

"It was unexpected given their previously strong support, and at no point did they articulate anything specific about Flock LPRs or their efficacy as a crime-fighting tool that led them to change their position," said Figlia. "I am cognizant, however, that elected officials certainly have a responsibility to listen to their constituents. I am grateful that in Beacon our elected officials will be making any decisions about LPRs with eyes wide open to public concerns, the safeguards our department put in place and the crimes that we have been able to solve with their use."

Parisi said that the Analysis and Real-Time Crime Intelligence Center, Flock technology and broader use of license-plate readers were pursued as public-safety initiatives. Imperati said the officials' statement does not change his belief that regulated LPR technology can have legitimate investigative value, "but believing a technology can be useful does not mean government should continue using it when the people it serves have raised serious concerns."

Parisi and Imperati said they will work with county officials to address the steps necessary to discontinue the use of Flock technology, including operational and contractual obligations.

In Putnam County, Sheriff Brian Hess spoke to the Legislature's Protective Services Committee on Sept. 9 **about the county's 48 cameras**, which are not tied to the Flock system. Data collected by the cameras is stored with the Real Time Crime Center in Westchester County, whose police department is accused in a lawsuit of illegally tracking drivers and allowing access by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement.

Mike Armstrong of Cold Spring raised several concerns during the Putnam meeting, including the lack of a contractual agreement governing how the county shares data with other agencies and the potential for misuse, including ICE using the data to locate and detain people. “Our imaginations have all been awakened in the last few years about what the potential could be,” he said.

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Ralph Pettorossi

According to Flock, its cameras found 10,000 missing persons in 2025. At the same time, the Institute for Justice has documented 259 cases of “abuse” since 2023 — leading me to believe, once again, there is nothing worse than a hysterical, uninformed citizen or a soft-on-crime liberal.

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